



The British prime minister at the time, Lord North, broke down and sobbed when he heard the news.

Birth of a nation

After the British withdrew, Loyalists were allowed to remain, but about 2 percent opted to emigrate to Canada and the Caribbean.

The British government gave the Americans their independence in return for a trade agreement that would benefit both sides. The Treaty of Paris, signed in 1783, gave the Americans a western border on the Mississippi, and control of the Old North West—an area extending from the Ohio and Mississippi rivers to the Great Lakes.

Conflicts over the issue of slavery threatened to divide the nation, but the new republic had great political hopes, which they set out in the 1781 Articles of Confederation, and later the Constitution of June 21, 1788. George Washington was elected as the first president in 1789, giving the federal



Stars and Stripes

Dating from about 1830, this hand-sewn flag has 13 stars and 13 stripes, to commemorate the 13 original colonies that rebelled against the British.

(central) government exclusive power in the conduct of diplomacy, commerce, and war. Congress was to consist of two chambers, the Senate and the House of Representatives. In addition, a Supreme Court was set up to interpret laws and safeguard the Constitution, which stated that all men were born equal, and had an equal voice in government.

French territories were incorporated into the United States, but the growing north-south divide eventually led to civil war.

FURTHER EXPANSION

The **new nation quickly expanded** to the south and west. Ohio became a state in 1803, Indiana in 1816, Illinois in 1818, and Alabama in 1819. In 1803 President Jefferson purchased the Louisiana territory from France **310 >>**

WAR OF 1812

Fought under the motto “**free trade and sailor’s rights**,” the War of 1812 against Britain was a result of British maritime policies during the Anglo-French wars when American sailors were seized and forced into the British navy. President James Madison saw the war as a way to **strengthen republicanism**, and believed it could secure possession of Canada as a bargaining chip against Great Britain. Although three attempts were made to invade Canada, all of them ended in failure. The war

was, however, the first step in establishing the US as a serious, and permanent, presence in **international politics**.

CIVIL WAR

The US was divided on **the issue of slavery**.

For years, slaves were used on southern plantations, but in the north slave labor was forbidden. Eventually, seven southern states split from the Union when Abraham Lincoln **316–17 >>**

was elected president and, in 1861, formed the **Confederate States of America 314–15 >>**. They were later joined by four other states. Civil war broke out, as the North tried to save the Union. The war ended in 1865 with victory for the Union, but it led to economic disruption. **Slavery was abolished**, but Abraham Lincoln was assassinated in the month the war ended.



CONFEDERATE OFFICER'S CAP

